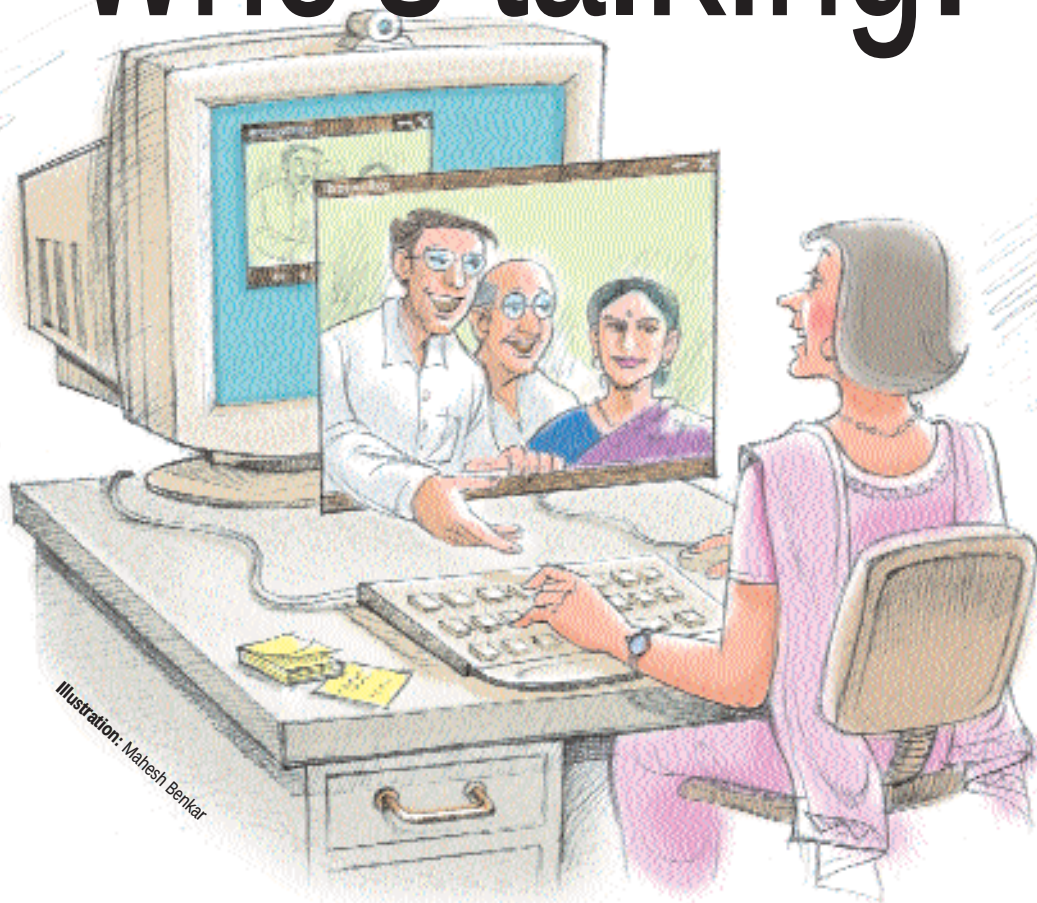


LOOK who's talking!



Don't reach for the phone the next time you want to call a friend—instead just get out your headset and start videoconferencing

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The telephone was a milestone in the field of communication, but it has now been overshadowed by Internet chat. Voice over Internet, although illegal, gives you a minimal bill for frequent overseas calls. But now you no longer have to be content with just listening to the voices of your near and dear ones—thanks to videoconferencing, you can see and talk with your son or daughter settled abroad, over the Internet, right there on your PC.

The right gear

The first thing that you need to do is check the hardware. The bare essentials you would need are a PC, an Internet connection, a Web camera and a speaker-microphone combination.

Choose a camera that would give you the best performance (see box, 'Buying a Web cam?').

There are certain tweaks that could help your camera take better pictures, but tweaks don't always work. A cheaper camera wouldn't deliver a good image to the recipient and you would just be adding another piece of hardware to your collection. Opt for a better camera, though such a camera would be priced higher.

After you've arranged for all the hardware requisites to start a videoconference session, what you need is software that will help you use all of these gadgets together and talk with a person in another corner of the world. A search on the Internet can get you a good number of video chatting software.

Videoconferencing software can broadly be classified into two categories: software that evolved from Instant Messengers and programs that started off as a video chat client itself. Yahoo! and MSN messengers fall into the former